

The thread, *at a glance*

A future with AI that doesn't leave the human behind. It hands the hours back, so the people at Pathos can spend them on the *touch points* that made Pathos in the first place: the idea, the craft, the relationship.

THE GOAL

Make Pathos more efficient, without losing what makes it Pathos. One written model of Pathos at its best, a benchmark every team, process and new tool is measured against. Higher efficiency means the same team delivers faster, has room for more work, and can bring in more income every month. **1**

WHAT WE HEARD **2**

- **Human touch points.**
The repetitive work can go. The idea, the judgment and the relationship stay with the person.
- **No tool carousel.**
Stay current without the team relearning a new tool every other month.
- **Say it before you build it.**
Requirements first, then delivery, agreed before the first hour of work.
- **Better, not fewer.**
More reach for every person, nobody replaced, and pace with the agencies already using AI well.
- **Knowledge that stays.**
A way of working stays in the house for whoever comes next.
- **Thirty hours, three hours.**
When the work takes a tenth of the time, what does the invoice say?

THE THESIS

- Process over person. **3****
How Pathos works is written down per process, so it belongs to the agency and stays when someone moves on.
- Capability over tool. **4****
Each process names the kind of help it needs. The tool is a field you can change.
- Value over hours. **5*****
The client pays for what the work makes possible. The hour becomes an internal number.

THE OPENING

87%

USE GEN AI

6%

A LINE OF BUSINESS

Almost every US agency uses these tools. Very few have turned them into a line of business. That gap is where Pathos can lead.

6

FORRESTER WITH THE 4AS, APRIL 2026

THE APPROACH

How we'd *get there*

THE METHODS

01 Process Registry 7

How Pathos works, written down per process and owned by the agency. The asset everything else attaches to.

03 Economics Ledger 9

What each process took to build, costs to run and made possible. Process first, cost later.

05 Requirements & Delivery 11

Two short documents agreed before work starts: what is needed, then how it will be delivered.

02 Automation Map 8

The kind of help each process needs and which tool fills it today, with OpenClaw as a replaceable orchestrator.

04 Feedback loop 10

Better ways get proposed, looked at, and promoted into the standard, with the reason kept.

06 Training per process 12

A learning space and a Pathos knowledge base. Learn, do, write back, promote.

THE PATH

THE NEXT WEEKS

Understand and design 13

Time with the teams, Alex's guidance on tools and systems, a first target chosen, and both documents written.

MONTHS ONE TO THREE

Prove it in one department 14

An OpenClaw operator per role, set up with the person. The ledger on real work, the training loop turning.

AFTER

Grow the thread 15

The next departments, faster each time, and a second brain for Shane and the department heads.

WHO DOES WHAT

Shane Savage

PATHOS · CSO

Direction, the first target, the final say on the standard.

Alex Fagard

PATHOS · TECHNOLOGY

Our guide to the tools, the systems and where a new piece fits.

Jeffrey Reinhold

TRIBUNE · CTO

Strategy, architecture, OpenClaw setup, training design.

Ryan Poole

TRIBUNE · CEO

The second brain for leadership, from running Maximus AI.

BEFORE WE START

01

An hour with Alex

How work and tools run today, and his view on the approach.

02

The departments

In Shane's words, or any document that already describes them.

03

A first target

The team or process where this should prove itself first.

A little more *detail*

The numbered pins on pages A1 and A2, written out. Each note names the section it belongs to.

FROM PAGE A1 · AT A GLANCE

1 What more efficient means

THE GOAL

The model works as a benchmark. When a team takes on a new tool, or someone new joins, their way of working is compared with the model rather than with someone's memory, and the better of the two becomes the standard.

Efficiency is counted in hours given back to people, never in people removed. AI takes the first pass at first drafts, versions, research and reporting, so the same team finishes work sooner and has room for more clients each month.

The full book, chapter seven, "The other side of the ledger", has a worked example with sample numbers and the research behind them.

2 Where each theme leads

WHAT WE HEARD

- **Human touch points:** decided per process, with the team: what stays with a person, what goes to AI first.
- **Better, not fewer:** more capacity per person, counted in hours back each week.
- **No tool carousel:** the Automation Map, note 8.
- **Knowledge that stays:** the Process Registry and training, notes 7 and 12.
- **Say it before you build it:** the two documents, note 11.
- **Thirty hours, three hours:** value over hours, note 5.

3 Process over person, in practice

THE THESIS

Take client onboarding. Today the best way to run it may live with one experienced account lead. Written down as a process, with the steps, the templates and that lead's own notes, a new colleague can run it in their first week.

The lead's way of working stays in the house, and the lead can keep refining it for everyone.

4 Capability over tool, in practice

THE THESIS

A process says what kind of help it needs, for example "a first draft of the creative brief", not which app to open. The tool that does it today is one line in a list.

When a better tool comes along, only that line changes. The process, the prompts and the training around it stay the same, so nobody has to relearn their job.

5 Value over hours, in practice

THE THESIS

If a campaign concept took 30 hours and now takes 3, billing 3 hours gives the gain away. Pricing the outcome keeps it: a fixed package for a launch, a campaign season or a brand refresh.

The client notices faster answers and more directions to choose from. The hours become an internal number that tells Pathos its margin.

6 Reading the numbers

THE OPENING

In a survey of about 200 US agency leaders, 87% said they use generative AI and 81% use it to make their teams more productive. Yet 61% still count it as a cost of doing business, and only 6% have made it part of what they sell.

Most agencies use AI quietly, inside the building. Very few have turned it into an offer clients can see and buy.

Source: The State of AI Inside US Marketing Agencies 2026, Forrester with the 4As, April 2026.

FROM PAGE A2 · THE APPROACH

7 Process Registry

THE METHODS

A shared, living record of how work gets done at Pathos, one entry per process. Each entry names who owns it, what starts it, the steps, what comes out at the end, and how much of it is automated.

Example: client onboarding starts when a contract is signed and runs through the kickoff call, a structured brief, scope and estimate, and client sign-off. It is written with the people who do the work, and it is worth having even for processes that never get automated.

8 Automation Map

THE METHODS

For each process, a short list of the kinds of help it uses, such as drafting, research, reporting or media, and which tool fills each one today. Because the process names the job and not the product, a tool can be swapped without rewriting the work.

OpenClaw, the AI orchestration platform we work with, is the layer that connects those tools and runs on hardware Pathos owns. It is built to stay for years, and built so that even it could be replaced without starting over.

9 Economics Ledger

THE METHODS

An internal record, per process, of what it took to set up, what it costs to run each month, how many hours it saves, and whether quality held.

It is filled in only once a process is written down and running, so the numbers describe real work rather than estimates. It tells Pathos its margin and which processes are worth expanding. Clients never see it.

10 Feedback loop

THE METHODS

When someone finds a better way to do a task, such as a prompt, a shortcut or a new tool, they suggest it for that process instead of quietly doing it their own way.

A named person looks at it. If it works, it becomes the new standard, with a note on who suggested it and why. If not, it is kept on file with the reason, so good ideas reach everyone and nothing is argued twice.

11 The two documents

THE METHODS · REQUIREMENTS & DELIVERY

Two short documents, agreed before any work starts.

The Requirements Book is written by whoever needs the work: what has to be achieved and why, what "done" looks like, and the limits of time, budget and taste.

The Delivery Book is written by whoever does the work: how it will be done, by whom, in which steps, and how everyone will know it is finished.

Between Tribune and Pathos, Pathos's needs shape the first and we write the second. Between Pathos and a client, the client's brief becomes the Requirements Book and Pathos's proposal becomes the Delivery Book. The client signs off on outcomes rather than hours, and any later change is agreed in writing.

12 Training per process

THE METHODS

Training belongs to the process, not to a person or a tool. It lives in two places: a learning space with short videos and walkthroughs, in the style of LearnWorlds or Skool, and a Pathos knowledge base where each process, its history and the team's notes are kept.

People learn a process, run it, write back what they would change, and the good changes become the new standard. A new hire starts from what the team already knows.

13 Understand and design

THE PATH · THE NEXT WEEKS

A few hours with each team to watch a normal week of work, and a conversation with Alex about the tools and systems already in place.

From that, we choose a first target together, write the Requirements and Delivery Books for it, and agree on scope and pricing before anything is set up.

14 Prove it in one department

THE PATH · MONTHS ONE TO THREE

Starting with one department gives real results quickly without spreading thin. Each person in that team gets an OpenClaw assistant, set up with them for their role, for example one that turns kickoff call notes into a first draft of the brief.

The ledger tracks what changes. After about three months, those results decide what comes next.

15 Grow the thread

THE PATH · AFTER

Once one department runs well, the same approach moves to the next, faster each time because the registry, the tools and the training already exist.

At that point a second brain for leadership becomes possible: an AI assistant that prepares research before meetings, lays out options with their costs, and shows what is on track across departments. Ryan runs his own company this way. The decisions stay with Shane and the department heads.